



Filipa Calado <fcalado@pratt.edu>

Project Progress Summary: Federal Anti-Trans Legislation Tracker

2 messages

Michaela Jackson <mjack245@pratt.edu>

Sat, May 17, 2025 at 12:15 AM

To: Filipa Calado <fcalado@pratt.edu>

Hello Filipa,

I wanted to give you a detailed update on where I left off with the federal legislation tracking project so it'll be easy to pick up from here if needed.

Over the course of the project, I built a Python-based pipeline to collect, clean, and organize data on federal anti-trans legislation introduced in 2024 and 2025. The goal was to create a comprehensive dataset that not only includes metadata (like bill titles, categories, and summaries) but also links to the official full-text documents hosted on [congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov). The primary source for scraping was [TransLegislation.com](https://translegislation.com).

What's Completed:

- **Web Scraping:** I scraped bill cards for both 2024 and 2025, extracting the title, caption, category, and description for each bill. I also followed each card's detail page to gather LegiScan and [congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov) links.
 - This was completed for 2024.
 - For 2025, I collected only [congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov) links due to inconsistencies in LegiScan formatting.
- **DataFrames:** I stored the scraped data in two DataFrames (df24 and df25) and exported them as 2024CSV and 2025CSV.
- **Combining and Enriching the Dataset:**
 - I merged both DataFrames into df_combined.
 - I extracted the congressional session number from the [congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov) links using a regex function.
 - Parsed each bill title to extract the identifying bill number (e.g., "HR 10075").
 - Identified the bill type (e.g., house bill, senate resolution) and mapped it to a standardized code (like hr, sres, etc.).
 - Filled in missing bill types manually where needed.
- **Constructing XML URLs:**
 - I used the session, bill number, and bill type to build direct XML links to the full bill text on [congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov) (e.g., <https://www.congress.gov/119/bills/hr1015/BILLS-119hr1015ih.xml>).
 - Validated the links and manually entered missing or alternate ones.
 - Stored these in a new column called xml_url.
- **Retrieving and Cleaning Bill Text:**
 - I downloaded the full text for each bill from the XML links and saved it to a file called Bill_text.txt.
 - Then, I used BeautifulSoup to clean up the XML content and remove any HTML noise.
 - The result is a list of cleaned full-text bill documents saved as cleaned_text.txt.

Current Status:

The merged dataset includes:

- All bill metadata
- Bill number, type, session number
- XML link to full text
- Cleaned bill text (in a separate list, not yet joined)

All files are saved and pushed to the GitHub repository. The main notebook (tracker_federal.ipynb) contains the entire pipeline. Other files in the repo include both CSVs, the raw and cleaned text files, and a few early test exports.

Suggested Next Steps:

- Finalize or attempt recovery of 2025 LegiScan links (optional)
- Align the cleaned full-text entries with their corresponding bill rows in df_combined
- Begin analysis — potential directions include:

- Keyword extraction or topic modeling
- Word clouds or frequency analysis
- Year-over-year comparisons of legislative focus

I will also use this summary to make a readme and add to my portfolio!

Best,

Michaela

Filipa Calado <fcalado@pratt.edu>
To: Michaela Jackson <mjack245@pratt.edu>

Wed, Jun 4, 2025 at 11:59 AM

Thank you SO MUCH Michaela. And I am so sorry for the delay in responding to you.

This is such great work, and super helpful moving forward.

It was great to work with you this semester, and to have you in class last fall. I hope you stay in touch. Please feel free to put me down as a reference for any job (or job type) of apps.

One more thing --- it was lovely to see you walk across the stage last month! Hope you are taking the time to fully celebrate your accomplishment :) These moments are rare and wonderful.

Stay well, and keep in touch!

Filipa
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